

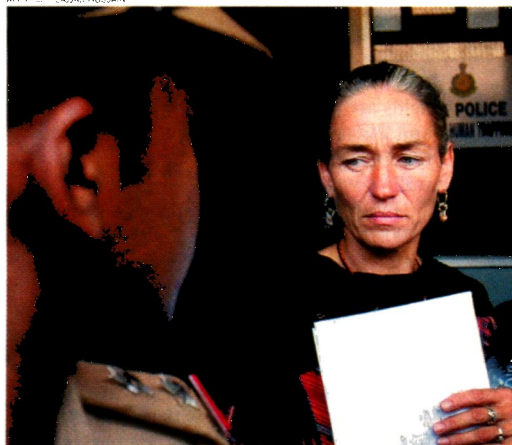
Everyone's favourite party place is being pushed to the edge by the drug mafia, hippies, avaricious builders and venal politicians who have turned a virtual paradise into an increasingly dangerous place

■ By Aditi Pai in Panjim

Goa is a state, but also a state of mind. Everything here moves at a different pace from the rest of India—the people, work style, meals, partying or building a house. *Susegad* (laidback) was how locals described the ambience and their attitude to life. It was what made Goa such a charming holiday place: easy-going, tourist-friendly, green with forests and fields, pristine beaches, historic churches, quaint villages, and a wide range of accommodation, not to mention the locals' love for music and the easy availability of soft drugs. Over the years, as Goa turned into the Ibiza of the East, its darker, seamier side started showing. It took one British woman with a dubious background, multiple partners and a brood of illegitimate children, one of whom was raped and murdered a few weeks ago, to expose just how dark and just how seamy it was.

APRIL 7, 2008 • INDIA TODAY

A BRITISH TEENAGER'S MURDER HAS EXPOSED GOA'S DARKER SIDE, HIDDEN BENEATH THE FACADE OF AN IDYLIC HOLIDAY PLACE



FIONA MACKEOWN, MOTHER OF THE MURDERED TEENAGER

The state's seedy side had always existed, hidden behind the dunes and rocks at secluded beaches. But the rift between *susegad* Goa and its new, concretised, crime and corruption-infested image is more pronounced now. Goa's skyline is the most visible sign of the sea change the state has gone through. Stand along the peaceful Mandovi river and the hillock you see across is dotted with houses and factories; orchards and paddy

JANUARY 2008

A Russian was molested by the owner of a shack at Uttorda beach. On the pretext of offering her a lift, he forced her into his jeep and tore off her T-shirt.

DECEMBER 2007

A Canadian national was raped by a fellow Canadian tourist at a south Goa hotel. The woman, supposedly in her 30s, was staying in the same hotel as the accused.